Scaling Consulting in the Age of AI

Schulich Dean's Cup 2025-26 Finale

sponsored by

CONFIDENTIAL

Disclaimer: This case study has been developed solely for educational and academic purposes as part of the Schulich School of Business case competition sponsored by Optimus SBR. The information presented in this case, including all financial figures, company names, and scenarios, is fictional and intended to facilitate a learning experience. Any resemblance to actual companies, events, or persons, living or dead, is purely coincidental. The content of this case should not be construed as factual, nor should it be interpreted as legal, financial, or business advice. Optimus SBR, Schulich School of Business, and the case authors make no representations or warranties of any kind, express or implied, regarding the completeness, accuracy, reliability, suitability, or availability of the information within this case study. Any actions taken based on this content are strictly at the participant's discretion and risk. Neither Optimus SBR, Schulich School of Business, nor the case authors shall be held liable for any losses, damages, or claims arising from the use or misuse of the material in this case. Participants are encouraged to seek independent advice or verification when appropriate.

optimus sbr

Background

The global management consulting industry is undergoing one of its most significant transformations in decades. Advances in artificial intelligence, automation, and digital platforms are reshaping how organizations solve problems, make decisions, and deliver services.

Historically, consulting firms have relied on teams of experts conducting analysis, developing strategies, and supporting implementation through project-based engagements. New technologies, particularly generative AI and agent-based systems—are rapidly altering this model. Clients increasingly expect faster insights, real-time analytics, and scalable solutions rather than traditional consulting deliverables.

At the same time, consulting clients face growing pressure to modernize operations, adopt AI responsibly, and deliver measurable outcomes. This has led to a shift in expectations: organizations now seek partners who can combine **strategy**, **technology**, and **execution**.

For consulting firms, this raises an important strategic question: should they continue to rely primarily on people-driven advisory models, or evolve toward hybrid models that combine consulting expertise with technology-enabled delivery?

Optimus SBR is Canada's largest independent management consulting firm. We help organizations solve complex operational, strategic, and technological challenges, combining insight with execution to deliver tangible results. Serving financial services, government, healthcare, and a broad range of other industries, we bring deep expertise and an unrelenting commitment to execution. Our key practice areas include strategy, process and project management, AI, digital transformation, data and analytics, technology consulting, and experience management. With an execution-focused approach and a people-first culture, Optimus SBR helps clients move beyond strategy to drive sustainable growth.

As AI technologies rapidly reshape the consulting landscape, Optimus leadership is exploring how the firm should evolve to remain competitive over the next 5 years.

The Challenge

Optimus SBR has asked your consulting team to evaluate how Optimus SBR should adapt their **business model, services, and delivery approach** in a world increasingly powered by AI.

Your team must develop a strategic recommendation answering the following question:

How should Optimus SBR evolve their delivery model and capabilities to remain competitive and create differentiated value for clients in the age of AI?

CONFIDENTIAL

The Challenge Key Questions to Address

Your team should consider the following questions in your recommendation:

- How will AI and automation reshape the consulting industry over the next 2-5 years?
- What capabilities will consulting firms need to develop to remain competitive? Assume the consulting firms are beyond the experiential phase, what's next?
- Should consulting firms invest in proprietary technology platforms or AI-enabled services?
- How might consulting delivery models evolve (e.g., subscription services, digital platforms, hybrid consulting)?
- What organizational changes may be required to support this transformation?
- What risks should consulting firms anticipate as AI adoption accelerates?

Your final recommendation should include a clear strategy for how consulting firms can create sustainable competitive advantage in an AI-driven market.

Appendices

Appendix A – Canadian Consulting Market Overview

Metric	Estimate
Canadian consulting market size	~C$17–18B
Annual industry growth rate	~5%
Largest segments	Strategy, Operations, Technology
Fastest-growing segments	Digital transformation, AI, Cloud / Data & Analytics

Technology consulting and digital transformation services have been the fastest-growing segments of the industry over the past decade.

Appendix B – Talent and Workforce Implications

AI is also reshaping the consulting workforce.

Key considerations for consulting firms include:

- How consultant roles may evolve as AI increasingly automates analysis and reporting tasks.
- The new capabilities and skills consultants will need to develop, such as data science, AI governance, and product development.
- How AI can be leveraged to augment consultant capabilities rather than replace them.

The consulting workforce of the future may combine domain expertise, technology fluency, and data-driven decision-making capabilities.

CONFIDENTIAL